

Motorola SLVR L9

A no-nonsense candy-bar

The MOTO SLVR line features typical, no-nonsense, slim candy-bar phones with a reasonable amount of features. The SLVR L9 is the successor of the L7; in the looks department, the two are nearly identical.

Despite it being entry-level, the fit and finish of the L9 are surprisingly good. The pearl-grey finish is as good as that on the more expensive RAZR 2. The back cover is finished in rubberised material, and therefore offers good grip.

A 2-inch, 256 colour, 176 x 220 LCD is more than enough for this phone. The screen is sharp and bright, and stays perfectly legible outdoors. The navigational keys consists of a roundel and two soft menu keys. There are two additional buttons (for Cancel and launching FM).

The keypad is well-spaced, with each key being separated from the other by small ridges; however, the tactile feedback isn't as good as that on the new RAZR 2, despite the visual similarities.

One of the prominent differences with respect to the older L7 is the fact that the memory slot is on the right. The L9 accepts microSD up to 2 GB (the

phone has just 20 MB of internal memory). With many phones supporting up to 4 GB of additional memory, this is a bit of a disappointment. The user interface on the L9 hasn't been upgraded to the newer MOTOMAGX—it uses the older, not-so-polished UI. Well, we should say it is easy to work with, but visually-speaking, Symbian's revised Series 40 is more intuitive.

Coming to multimedia, the SLVR L9 supports the MP3, AAC, AAC+ and MPEG4 formats. The media player is mediocre compared to that on the RAZR, and indeed, that of any music phone today. Audio quality is reasonably good.

The 2-megapixel camera is pretty much similar to that on the RAZR 2. The camera performs admirably outdoors; in low-light conditions and indoor environments, photos turn out dark. It's also capable of recording video in the MPEG4 format, but the quality is nothing to write home about.

We had no problems as far as signal reception goes, but the speakerphone clarity could have been better. Battery life is strictly okay—we got around two days with nominal usage. At Rs 8,399 the L9 is reasonably-priced; however, we can't see any compelling reason to recommend it to anyone.

Sony-Ericsson W910i

The Ultimate Walkman slider

The W910i is the latest in the Walkman series of phones from Sony Ericsson. It comes with a new media-browsing interface, and an inbuilt motion sensor for games and music.

The slim W910i employs a smooth slider mechanism. The front facia is dominated by a (huge!) 2.4-inch LCD screen—strikingly beautiful, and it remains perfectly legible even in direct sunlight.

The navigational keys include a small steel five-way rocker which doubles up as the Playback control when using media player, and two soft menu keys. Two additional keys are placed near the top, which are configured for the photo album by default; they can be used while gaming as well. The flat keypad lacks tactile feedback and feels mushy—not good if you SMS a lot. The Power On and Walkman buttons at the top are rather difficult to operate.

Music is the forte of the W910i. Playback quality is awesome; the bundled earphones are simply superb, plus you can use any 3.5 mm earphones you'd like. Two features have been added, called Shake control and SenseMe. Shake Control, as the name suggests, implies the use of motion

sensors (gyroscopes, to be precise) to control music playback. Shake the phone in one direction to switch to the next track and in the other direction for the previous track—you've no doubt seen this in the advertisements for the phone. The feature works overall, but it needs refinement. SenseMe is a kind of media browser where tracks are sorted by tempo (like fast or slow) and mood (happy or sad). For a song to be tagged with the right mood, it needs to be uploaded via the Media Manager application (otherwise it remains hidden from SenseMe).

The camera on the W910i is decent, but not the best; you'd have expected SE to do better. As with all 2MP cameras, it performs better outdoors; image quality decreases with light. Video recording is okay.

The phone itself is typical SE—a simple user interface and snappy performance. A 2 GB card is included, and you also get a USB reader with this phone. The only gripe we had with the phone was the keypad, which has no tactile feedback, and feels like the buttons on washing machines.

The W910i is easily the best of the W series of phones from SE. Retailing at Rs 18,899, we'd recommend the W910i to someone looking for a suave, slim music phone.

Sony-Ericsson K810i

Good as a camera phone

The K810i comes from Sony Ericsson's Cyber-shot series. The 3.2-megapixel camera sensor is what differentiates this phone from the crowd and from other SE phones. The 810i is aimed at causal shutterbugs, and has some neat features that should go down well with that audience.

The translucent body with steel buttons gives the phone its unique appearance. The phone is quite long, but is comfortable to hold. The back cover is finished in rubberised material, and that gives the phone excellent grip, which is good for clicking snaps.

The navigational keys are similar to those on older SE phones such as the K750i. The joystick is much better, though, and well-recessed. The soft menu keys and additional shortcuts keys are small and tightly placed; this could turn out to be a problem for some. The keypad is well-spaced-out, and consists of little round keys—much better than those on the K550i or the W880i. At first sight, the keypad might seem uncomfortable, but you'll find it's not.

The 3.2MP camera is well-protected by a sliding lens cover. Being a Cybershot, it has one-touch shortcut keys to change flash modes, timer, Macro, and megapixel rating. One row of the keypad has the appropriate markings, and gets highlighted when camera

mode is activated. There are two buttons near the top, for changing the shooting mode and scenes. The Auto-focus works well and locks on the subject immediately, but in low light, it takes a while. There is a reasonably powerful xenon flash to light up the subject. Performance is quite what you'd expect from a 3-megapixel camera. Colours, sharpness, and detail were perfect; more importantly, the shooting experience is great.

The K810i can play music too, and the quality is above average; it can't match that of the Walkman series, though. Further, the bundled earphones are the regular ones (which come with entry-level Sony-Ericsson phones), not the Fontopias. The K810i supports MS micro memory cards; though SE has bundled 128 MB, it might not be enough if you plan to carry music and click photographs at 3 megapixels.

We had no issues with the phone performance; signal reception was good, and so was the voice clarity. Battery life is okay—expect around two days unless you plan to surf the Internet and use Bluetooth a lot.

The K810i retails at Rs 15,500; we say it's reasonable. In fact, we'd recommend the K810i to anyone looking out for a good camera phone.

Sony-Ericsson K850i

Some of this, some of that—and a great camera

The K850i is the flagship model in the Cyber-shot line-up from Sony-Ericsson. Based around a 5-megapixel camera, it's pitted against Nokia's N95 as far as the camera is concerned. The K850i comes in at a notch above the K810i.

The phone sports a completely revamped design, with hardly any resemblance to earlier SE models. It is blocky, but the fit and finish are excellent. A nice, luminous green strip runs around the edge.

The navigational D-pad is a squarish ring that surrounds the 2 and 5 number keys. The edges are raised for proper contact. There is no action button; rather, there are touch-sensitive buttons just below the screen. They are context-sensitive and are dynamically assigned the proper functions, similar to soft menu buttons. The touch-sensitive buttons work flawlessly, but require some time to get used to. The backlight at times seems overpowering, and distracts. The keypad consists of small square buttons—usable, but no fun when texting.

The camera is at the back, and the lenses have their own retracting cover. A hard plastic sheet is drawn over the length of the phone, covering the lens. It protects the shiny back of the phone, but also attracts fingerprints; when clicking, you'll need to clean the portion near the lens.

The K850i is designed to deliver a digital-camera-like experience, and it doesn't disappoint. The camera controls have evolved over the K810i, and the ergonomics are much better. Since the K850i doesn't have any additional dedicated buttons, most settings can be changed from the single touch-sensitive button.

Camera performance was superb; colour accuracy is pretty impressive—better than that on the N95. The K850i feels snappier throughout; it starts in an instant, file saves are fast, and it switches back to the phone in a second. Indoors, the camera has a tendency to underexpose if the flash is used.

The K850i comes with 40 MB of internal memory, and a 512 MB MS micro card comes bundled, but with a 5 megapixel camera and music, you'll have to buy more memory. Music-wise, the phone is on par with the K810i, and it betters the N95, but can't match any of the W series phones.

Priced at Rs 21,000, the K850i is 10K cheaper than the Nokia N95. It misses out on GPS and WiFi, but it has a much better camera and music player, and longer battery life. Let's just say the K850i fits the bill if you want a good smartphone with an excellent camera.

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★●
Performance	★★★★●
Build Quality	★★★★●
Value for Money	★★★★●
Overall	★★★★●

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